The Development of Islamic Education[1]

1. The aim of Islamic education is the 'cultivation' of the individual so that he or she abides by and lives by the teachings of Islam. From an early period of its history, Islamic education began to grow into a dual (independent/government) form due to socio-political changes. While learning at the time of the Prophet (PBUH) had started as basic education in the mosque for all Muslims, the first century and a half of Islamic history produced various kinds of educational institutions and sciences. Some of these, as mentioned earlier, originated from ancient cultures, while others began with the Prophet (PBUH) and his Companions.

2. The elementary school, the kuttāb from the Prophetic period and the maktab, which was an Islamised Byzantine secondary school, evolved into one elementary school system. The second style of elementary education, where urban Arabs and later royalty sent their boys to the desert to be educated, grew into the tutor system, where the mu'addib was employed to teach at individual homes and in the palaces. This elementary education then led to further study at either the congregational (jāmi') or local mosque (masjid), where various literary and religious studies were taught in an open learning environment. Thus, the mosques may, in a loose way, be compared to college education in the modern world. Mosques, however, were not the only higher education institutions in the early first century of Islam; the chancery schools also provided for students who wanted to become administrators and secretaries in the government. The third type of higher education institution, the bimaristan, was connected to the natural sciences; it was based upon apprenticeship, where the student learnt from medical and scientific teachers in their teachers' homes or in hospitals. Although often carried out separately, both governments and scholars simultaneously advanced all these institutions and sciences. The scholars undertook the transmission of knowledge whereas the various governments sponsored and helped develop many of the educational institutions.

3. The initial period of the 'Abbasid era was not any different in the sphere of education from that of the Umayyads. Then what made the 'Abbasid period such a fertile time for scholarship and learning? The translation movement literarily

[1] Excerpts in these lecture notes draw exclusively from: Hussain, Amjad M.. A Social History of Education in the Muslim World: From the Prophetic Era to Ottoman Times (pp. 79-80). Ta-Ha Publishers Ltd. The hyperlinks in footnotes are mine. The notes do not assume students' familiarity with the scholars from the so-called Islamic Golden Age. Wherever possible I have provided footnotes carrying links to Wikipedia articles (as well as other sources) on the scholars mentioned in the text. Though not a mandatory reading, I encourage the students to glance the links in the footnotes as well.

changed the world for the new Islamic Caliphate, for by it new ideas and fresh streams of thought came to pour into the cities of Basra, Kufa and Baghdad. In addition, the scholars acknowledged that the religion of Islam confirmed the unity of all knowledge; rather than early Muslims suppressing the declining Greek intellectual tradition, they instead sought out its sources and encouraged it. Thus, all the early 'ulamā' of Islam were polymaths, not simply experts in the religious arena or in one subject only, but rather, they linked mathematics, philosophy, art, law and any other science together in explaining the world of Islam.310 Examples of such 'ulamā' ranged from scholars such …al-Kindi[2], philosopher, theologian and scientist; ar-Rāzī[3], physician and philosopher; al-Fārābī[4] philosopher; al-Bīrūnī[5], geographer, historian, linguist and scientist; Ibn Sīnā[6], the physician and philosopher; al-Ghazālī[7], the theologian, mystic and lawyer; and Ibn Rushd[8], the physician, judge and philosopher. All of the elementary and higher education institutions mentioned above were advanced in the forthcoming centuries under the 'Abbasid rule in such a way that this era would be remembered as, 'The Golden Age'.[9]

Elementary Education:

4. The Kuttāb or Maktab The kuttāb or maktab were more likely the same type of school, with the two terms used interchangeably throughout early Islamic history. This has been argued by many historians, beginning with the grammarian scholar al-Mubarrad[10] (d. 898), who maintained that the word maktab was the only grammatically correct term for the elementary school and not kuttāb. Shalaby described the elementary schools as a place where, "Learning the Qur'an preceded everything, next came religious instructions with some poetry, elementary grammar and arithmetic (with this) the primary course was closed."

5. After this description of the elementary school he notes that the curriculum obviously varied from one place to another by giving an example from the Muqadima of Ibn Khaldūn,[11] however, he provides no evidence of any changes in this elementary education during the early centuries of Muslim history. There seems to be an assumption that elementary education did not change during the seven centuries that lay between the Prophet's era and Ibn Khaldūn. For the reader it is

[2] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Al-Kindi
[3] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Abu_Bakr_al-Razi
[4] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Al-Farabi
[5] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Al-Biruni
[6] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Avicenna
[7] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Al-Ghazali
[8] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Averroes
[9] Yusuf Waghid, 'Educational Institutions: Can the Heritage Be Sustained', The American Journal of Islamic Sciences: Education, Vol. 14, (and Kuala Lumpur: The International Institute of Islamic Thought), Winter 1997, pp. 35-51.
[10] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Al-Mubarrad
[11] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ibn_Khaldun

already evident that education in all its forms did develop from the early period of Islamic history. The beginning of the kuttāb was a humble one; it was the teaching of reading, writing and the memorisation of the Qur'an in the mosque. However, by the end of the Umayyad period and the beginning of the 'Abbasid period this elementary institution, influenced by other various cultures, had advanced so much that it began to impart knowledge from a wide range of revealed sciences, adab[12] sciences and the natural sciences.

6. Makdisi[13] notes that by the Middle Ages this institution conveyed teaching at a much higher level than even contemporary elementary schools; it was de facto an institution that functioned as a 'finishing school' besides being an elementary school.

7. It is possible to find various statements littered throughout historical sources concerning the teachers and pupils of these schools. For example, the writer al-Katan during the eighth century noted the name of his mu'allim who was still alive when he was writing his book.

8. There are very few records that specify the exact age pupils commenced their elementary schools or when they left. The main reason for the lack of such information is more likely because the school system was not centrally organised by the state and since, all the elementary schools were independent and varied across the Muslim Caliphate, the age for the commencement of elementary education more likely varied widely. However, there are biographies of scholars that have helped shed light on the average age of pupils commencing leaving their elementary schools. After studying the various biographical sources, it appears that most pupils seem to have entered the school at the age of five, seven or even ten; however, it has to be remembered that this did not apply universally.

9. For example, [Imam] al-Bukhari[14] (d. 869) is reported to have completed his study by the time he was ten. Other students were known to have written academic books while still at the kuttāb.

10. It is reasonable to imagine that most pupils by the 'Abbasid period spent their young age to adolescent years in the kuttāb/maktab until they proceeded to higher education or became apprenticed to various crafts. Sources seem to indicate that most children in the Islamic world in the 'Abbasid period could read, write and do basic mathematics. In addition, by the later period of the 'Abbasid rule, the

[12] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Adab_(Islam)
[13] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/George_Makdisi
[14] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Muhammad_al-Bukhari

elementary schools had become extremely sophisticated; Makdisi points out that the maktab/kuttāb imparted such excellent training that numerous students went into further study of adab sciences, law studies and into government administration apprenticeship. Furthermore, there is evidence that pupils may have left one elementary school when they were finished and joined another school, for example Imam al-Bayhaqi[15] (994-1066) a scholar of fiqh and ḥadīth, left his first kuttāb/maktab after he had memorised and studied eleven books concerning sciences such as grammar, lexicography and poetry. It is reasonable to assume from earlier evidence concerning the curriculum of schools that he also had extensive knowledge concerning the revealed sciences, mathematics and literacy skills. He then joined his second kuttāb/maktab at the age of fifteen years and continued his adab studies where he memorised and studied four more works in the field of grammar and lexicography. After two years he left this school at the age of sixteen; he did not finish his studies here, however, he continued to study at a higher level under various masters.

Al-Mu'addib

11. By the beginning of the Umayyad dynasty, the desert education, which was a pre-Islamic elementary educational concept, was replaced by the tutor system. In contrast to the sources concerning the kuttāb/maktab, which are very few, the sources regarding the 'tutor system' are plentiful. The main group of tutors mentioned in the historical sources can be narrowed down to being the tutors of the royal and the wealthy families; these tutors had in-depth knowledge of both the religious and the adab sciences. This can be demonstrated by the following examples: the renowned grammarian and lexicographer al-Kisā'ī[16] (d. 805) was the mu'addib of the Caliph Hārūn ar-Rashīd (763-809), and later on he was the mu'addib of his children, Amīn (787-813) and Ma'mūn (786-833).

12. The Caliph's family were not the only ones during the 'Abbasid Caliphate who employed tutors for their children; the élite in the government and trade also sought out tutors for their children.

13. Throughout the 'Abbasid period the employment of mu'addib to tutor the children of the élite was a common and well-known practice. The tutors of that period can be divided into two types; the tutors who taught pupils of young age and the tutors who were known as an authority in their respective branches of knowledge, who taught the more advanced students. For example, Caliph Hārūn ar-Rashīd appointed Abū 'Abd aṣ-Ṣamad as the tutor for his young children, but when they grew up, he chose numerous specialists as mentioned above to educate his children.

[15] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Al-Bayhaqi
[16] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Al-Kisa%27i

14. The status of teaching the children of the élite was highly rewarded, sometimes with high pay or by material goods and sometimes even by becoming the confidant of the élite. There are many examples of such rewards; the tutor Aḥmar (d. 810) was originally a guard at the Caliph's palace who learnt his knowledge from the famous tutor al-Kisā'ī while at work. When a need for a tutor's assistant became necessary, al-Kisā'ī chose Aḥmar to succeed him. When Aḥmar became a tutor he was provided with a furnished home and a good salary. Another illustration of the reward for the tutors from the élite can be seen in the example of the scholar Abū 'Ubaid ibn Sallam[17], who was the tutor of Thābit al-Khuzai; al-Khuzai appointed Ubaid ibn Sallam as the magistrate of the city when he became the governor of Tarsus.

15. The greatest influence of the tutors in the society on the other hand, lay in their network. The successful tutors were able to choose their own disciples as tutors; much of the time these disciples were family members, thus at some point during the period of the 'Abbasid era, there were dynasties of tutors who tutored for the same families of élites. Many tutors moved from being tutors to holding posts in the government and becoming confidants of the caliphs that they had educated, leaving behind their own family members as tutors for the next generation.

Higher Education in the 'Abbasid Period The Mosque and the Khan[18]

16. During the era of the early Islamic civilisation, the distinction between elementary education and higher education was very clear and **the mosque was the main educational centre for higher education**.

17. The mosques were used as schools to teach adults Islam and literacy. By the Umayyad period two types of mosque emerged: '**al-masjid', the local mosque for the five daily prayers, and 'al-masjid al-jāmi" the major mosque at which the Jumu'ah prayer is held.**

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[17] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Abu_Ubaid_al-Qasim_bin_Salam

[18] **khan**, type of inn once found in the Middle East and parts of North Africa and Central Asia that effectively functioned as a trading centre and hostel. A square courtyard was surrounded by rows of connected lodging rooms, usually on two levels and arcaded. Although some stable space was provided, the khan was intended primarily for people, providing food as well as shelter for travelers and traders. The earliest extant khans, found in Syria, date to the Umayyad period. In the 16th century, under Ottoman rule, khans became one feature of a larger complex that could include a mosque, a fortress, a bath, and other amenities.
Although khans are often confused with caravansaries (a public building used for sheltering caravans and other travelers), khans were much smaller than caravansaries and were built within towns rather than on the outskirts. Modern motels and motor inns may be considered descendants of the khan and attest to the success of the design, with their easy access to rooms and storage space for transport.
https://www.britannica.com/technology/khan-architecture

18. The mosque curriculum grew to teach the *revealed sciences* and *adab*. In the ‘Abbasid period, the majority of the local masājid began to be utilised for study circles concerned with law and jurisprudence. In addition, during the early ‘Abbasid period, adab was taught extensively at the local mosques; the masjid al-jāmi‘ also included various study circles concerned mostly with jurisprudence but also adab studies.
19. The confirmation of the existence of such a higher education system is often found in various books written by later Muslim scholars concerning social issues, especially relating to the biographies of scholars or the categorisation of the sciences. In at-Tārīkh al-Baghdādī,[19] the author, while writing the biographies of the scholars who lived or visited this city, also notes the importance of various mosques and their educational use in the new city of Baghdad. Although some mosques were well known for being educational centres for particular subjects, this did not mean that these mosques were not used for other sciences as well. As has been seen in earlier chapters, the first centre of Islamic education was the Prophetic city of Madīnah, followed by the cities of Basra, Kufa and Damascus. By the ‘Abbasid period, Baghdad had become the main educational centre of the Muslim world. There were six main jāmi‘ mosques in the city of Baghdad during the ‘Abbasid period.

20. The first to be constructed was the Jāmi‘ Madīnat al-Manṣūr built between the years 762-766 CE and named after its founder, the second caliph of the ‘Abbasids. This mosque became well known as one of the greatest educational institutions during that epoch in the Muslim world. It is reported that around fifty ḥalaqāt were active when ash-Shāfi‘ī, the famous Imām of jurisprudence, visited Baghdad half a century after the mosque’s construction. The various ḥalaqāt contained recitation of the Qur’an, reporting and dictation of ḥadīth, poetry, tafsīr and even kālām, the science of ‘aqīdah, but this was rare. Although it is true that fiqh was later taught mostly at the local masjid, during the early period, throughout the third, fourth and the beginning of the fifth Islamic century, fiqh was taught continuously at the congregational mosques. Ash-Shāfi‘ī himself taught fiqh in one of the ḥalaqāt at the Jāmi‘ Madīnat al-Manṣūr and the guild of Shāfi‘ī scholars continued to teach at the mosque, however, this does not mean that the other guilds of law were excluded. The Ḥanbalī scholar Abū ‘Alī al-Hāshimī (d. 1037) taught fiqh and had a ḥalaqah for fatwa at the same mosque. The Ẓāhirī guild also had a few scholars teaching there, amongst them the founder of the guild Dāwūd ibn ‘Alī aẓ-Ẓāhirī.[20] The Jāmi‘ al-Ruṣafā, the second jāmi‘ mosque in Baghdad, built by the Caliph al-Mahdī in 775 CE, was mostly used for teaching by ḥadīth scholars.

[19] https://kitaabun.com/shopping3/tarikh-baghdad-madinatus-salam-khatib-baghdadi-p-6561.html
[20] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dawud_al-Zahiri

21. Most of the other mosques in Baghdad were also venues for specialised higher education. Ḥadīth ḥalaqāt were taught regularly by various scholars at local mosques, such as Masjid al-Bazzāzūn (the mosque of the fabric merchants), Masjid Ibn Raghbān, Masjid ʻAffān, Masjid Ibn Shāhīn, Masjid al-Baghiyyīn and Masjid Abū Bakr al-Hudhalī al-Baṣrī. Other local mosques, such as Masjid ad-Dāraquṭnī, Masjid ar-Ruwaym ibn Yazīd, Masjid aṣ-Ṣaḥābah and Masjid Ibn Mujāhid, where the famous Qur'an scholar Ibn Mujāhid taught his students the science of qirā'ah in the tenth century, functioned as educational institutions for the recitation of the Qur'an.

22. Others, such as Masjid ʻAbdullāh ibn al-Mubārak, were utilised for teaching Shāfiʻī fiqh, in this case by the well known Shāfiʻī scholar, ʻAbd al-Majīd.

23. During the period of Baghdad's foundation, a number of Sufi scholars appeared on the scene of the world of education. They emphasised the importance of spirituality in Islam to a society that was becoming highly materialistic. Thus, numerous local mosques began to specialise in the teaching of the sciences of Sufism, such as, Masjid al-Shunayziyah, Masjid Maʻrūf al-Karkhī, Masjid as-Sammāk and Masjid al-Bāb al-Kunas. Various local and congregational mosques taught a number of the adab sciences rather than the range of revealed sciences. These ḥalaqāt were taught by scholars such as the famous historian Abū Jaʻfar Muḥammad ibn Jarīr aṭ-Ṭabarī (838–923), who taught his students history and exegesis of the Qur'an at the Masjid as-Sūq al-ʻAtīqah, Abū ʻAbdullāh ibn ʻArafah Nifṭawayh (d. 935), who taught biography and history at the Masjid al-Anbaryyīn, and Abū Bakr al-Anbarī (d. 940) who taught his students lexicography, grammar, history, Qur'anic exegesis, and poetry at the same mosque.

24. However, it was not only in Baghdad that mosques were widely used as educational institutions; throughout the ʻAbbasid period, various congregational mosques and local mosques outside Iraq became famous for education. The Umayyad mosque in Damascus had study circles where sciences such as Qur'anic exegesis, grammar and law were taught. The jāmiʻ masjid of Basra had study circles on grammar, taught by grammarians such as Yūnus ibn Ḥabīb (d. 778-810), al-Kisā'ī (d. 805), and al-Farrā' (d. 822). Other famous mosques for higher education in the Islamic Islamic world during this time were the old mosque of Cairo (Egypt), the congregational mosque in Cordoba (Spain), the congregational mosque of Aleppo (Syria), the congregational mosque of Alexandria (Egypt) and the mosque of Sinjar.

25. Historians often speak about the sundry dynasties of both East and West at the time of the ʻAbbasid caliphs as a political disaster for the power of the Caliphate. However, if looked at through a different lens, it becomes clear that it was largely due to the Sultans of these states that vast sums of money went into education,

culture and art. The idea of statehood at that time always fluctuated, and the various borders of neighbouring states were quite fluid. Thus, by the early tenth century, after the rise and fall of various petty states, three rival caliphs in Baghdad, Cairo and Cordoba came to rule three separate Caliphates for a short period of time. This, of course, led to political rivalries and disunity but, at the same time, the three Caliphates (‘Abbasid, Fatimid and the Cordoba Caliphate) vied to outdo each other in culture, education and art. Thus, centres of education and culture spread from Baghdad to numerous cities that became capitals of various states such as Cairo, Cordoba, Bukhara, Samarqand, Ghazna, Shiraz and Konya.

26. Various sciences during the ‘Abbasid period were taught or delivered differently simply because of the diversity of the sciences. An example of this is the core difference between the science of taṣawwuf and the science of fiqh. The latter is studied to understand the revealed law of Islam and the former is taught for the student to come spiritually closer to Allah. However, this does not mean that these sciences are fundamentally in opposition to each other. There are various historical sources that refer to scholars and students studying both fiqh and taṣawwuf and this is the case today in many societies. One famous Sufi teacher who taught in Baghdad during the ninth century was the scholar al-Junayd. He taught his students to have a balanced spirituality in accordance with the sharī‘ah (divine law) and the ḥaqīqah (the timeless spiritual truth).

27. The study of the above sciences was imparted differently because of their core structure and aims being poles apart, but the study of Qur’an reading and ḥadīth were conducted in a very similar way. The teaching of both Qur’an reading and ḥadīth reports was by definition an instruction. The methods that were employed in Qur’an instruction were qirā’ah (recitation), tilāwah (reading aloud) and ‘arḍ (submission to criticism).

28. The students first heard the recitation of the teacher and were then asked to read it back to the teacher for submission to criticism. The transmission of ḥadīths was done through samā‘: the teacher reported a ḥadīth, or the student or someone else read the ḥadīth out to the teacher, and the student memorised it and wrote it down in his notebook. It is interesting to note that whereas most other ḥalaqāt such as grammar, theology or fiqh were collectively called majlis at-tadrīs (translated as ‘class of teaching’), the ḥalaqāt of ḥadīth were collectively called majlis al-ḥadīth.

29. This was done in order to emphasise that in the study circles where the ḥadīth were reported and collected, the emphasis was not on study but on gathering the various sayings of the Prophet (PBUH).

30. The scholars of various subjects such as the Qur'an, ḥadīth, grammar, theology, and fiqh, were famous as students for their memorisation of texts regarding their respective subjects. It is important, however, to recognise that this memorisation was accompanied by understanding and evaluation of the texts. The famous historian aṭ-Ṭabarī (d. 923) advised Muslim scholars and students alike not only to acquire knowledge, but also to understand it; he advised this because many of his followers had begun to limit themselves to memorisation and note-taking. The continuation of this methodology would be to create one's own work.

31. Al-Ghazālī (d. 1111) argued that education was ultimately about creating a moral person and that it involved all aspects of learning – intellectual, religious, moral and even physical. Al-Ghazālī further contended that imparting theoretical learning had to conclude with the practical since that would create a person who acted morally and ethically according to the faith.

32. The scholar Ibn Sīnā (d. 1037) divided higher education into theoretical instruction, which led to apprenticeship in crafts, and into theoretical education which, today may be referred to as 'academic'. He divided academic teaching in higher education into two types: the transmitted (naqlī) and the intellectual ('aqlī).

Munāẓarah

33. The early 'Abbasid era is well known for its intellectual debates on the growing religious, scientific and humanistic studies. These exchanges seem to have been labelled majlis al-munāẓarah (exchange of views) and majlis al-mudhākarah (mutual reminder).

34. According to Makdisi, munāẓarah was used for disputation, and questions were encouraged because they were seen as the keys to knowledge. The various styles of disputation varied in status, place and style so much that disputation and debate could occur in the markets and mosques as well as in the palaces of the caliphs. The first such exchanges were initiated by the early 'Abbasid caliphs and they became so influential that soon the rich and the scholars commenced their own exchanges.

35. There seem to have been two particular reasons why the caliphs established a munāẓarah in the palace. Primarily, it was politically showing leadership; for example, some historians have argued that through the establishment there of disputation by various scholars on issues of numerous sciences, the caliph could be the judge and create a status for himself as the principal source of leadership. There may be some truth to this argument because even the architectural structure of the Round City has been suggested to represent centralised power and to vividly assert

the status of the caliph. The second reason for bringing scholars together for exchanges was in order to raise the awareness of Baghdad as an intellectual capital.

36. In many ways, both aims were successful; the exchanges which Caliph Hārūn ar-Rashīd (r. 786-809) and his son the Caliph al-Ma'mūn (r.813-831) attended as judges have been immortalised in folktales about Baghdad and remembered for the wisdom of the Caliphs' verdicts. An example of this can be seen in the description given by the educational historian, Shalaby, regarding the Caliph Ma'mūn's period in Baghdad, to which he refers as the 'Augustan period' of Arabic sciences in which his court was crowned with men of science and letters, poets, physicians and philosophers from every part of the civilized world. This type of disputation was copied by various governors and, later on, by sultans elsewhere to bolster their cities' and states' standing as intellectual centres.

37. The second type of munāẓarah was convened by scholars themselves in mosques or at their own homes. These exchanges were commenced by various teachers who encouraged their students to ask questions and to discuss the questions and the answers with each other. Abū Ḥanīfah (d. 765) encouraged debates amongst his students which he supervised.347 In many ways, this style of munāẓarah was a continuation of the education that students acquired in study circles. It created an intellectual atmosphere where the aim was to make the students understand conflicting ideas and listen to various teachers. This was pointed out by Ayyūb as-Sakhtiyānī (d. 748) when he stated, "A person will not know the mistakes of his teacher until he knows the conflicting ideas," and Khalīl ibn Aḥmad (d. 791) stated, "The sciences are padlocks and questions are the keys to them."

38. The third type of munāẓarah is very similar to the one mentioned above, except that this type of disputation was not pre-arranged between the scholars; it was spontaneous and could even commence in the market. Moreover, this type of disputation was more frequent in contrast to the other styles of munāẓarah which were arranged and announced to the public.

39. These scholarly discussions were often conducted in places such as shops, city squares and gardens. According to writers of the 'Abbasid period such as Abū'l-Faraj Muḥammad ibn Isḥāq an-Nadīm (d. 998) and Yaqūt ibn 'Abdullāh ar-Rūmī al-Ḥamawī (d. 1229), the most famous discussions and debates were held in books dealers' markets where the proprietors were often themselves men of learning.

40. There is no doubt that the aim of all of these discussions and debates was sometimes simply to advance in knowledge, which consequently led many students to unhesitatingly challenge renowned scholars. Indirectly this created an intellectual

environment where the teachers were constantly checked academically and had to prove their worth at each step of their careers. It can also be argued that, whether arranged or spontaneous, these debates were a source of great entertainment for the general populace of the city and at the same time they provided an opportunity for scholars to educate them.

41. It is important to note that sometimes these debates were also misused by unscrupulous men who would try to humiliate their opponent by deception and obtain self-advancement through misguided praise of their own work. Nevertheless, there were scholars who continuously pointed out the need to be honest and maintain humility when debating. The Sufi scholar Ḥātim al-Aṣamm (d.852) advised his fellow scholars concerning exchanges, by stating that the debater should be pleased when his opponent hits the mark, regretful when the adversary makes a blunder and should sincerely recognise his opponent's qualities.351 The famous scholar and lecturer of the Nizamiyah Madrasah, al-Ghazālī (d. 1111), pointed out good and bad points of munāẓarah in his book Iḥyā 'Ulūm ad-Dīn. He said that only qualified people should be part of a debate, so that they do not need to refer to other scholars, but would have the ability themselves to cite crucial evidence. He pointed out the necessity of only debating actual cases or circumstances that could arise in the future and not future scenarios commonly accepted as being highly unlikely. He also advised that if the issue was a matter of right and wrong then it would be better that it was done in private since the debaters would put all their effort into dealing with the subject and not playing to the gallery. The debate should be carried out with two aims, primarily, to get to the truth and secondly, to learn from one's opponents who should in this role be seen as teachers. Thus both sides should be willing to accept their errors, accept the truth and be willing to lose the argument for its sake. In addition, al-Ghazālī warns against the damaging aspects of debating for personal gain which can lead to envy, pride, malice, backbiting, self-righteousness and hypocrisy.

42. The munāẓarah included discussions on a wide range of topics, for example, kalām, fiqh, adab, and natural sciences, whereas it seems that the mudhākarah was used exclusively in ḥadīth studies.

43. The majority of the scholars of ḥadīth attended and discussed in mudhākarah throughout the 'Abbasid period. However, according to Makdisi, mudhākarah was also used in adab studies as instructive conversation; mudhākarah was famously used in the mosque of Basra, where Khalīl ibn Aḥmad (d. 791) used it in relation to grammar and poetry. It was later used for testing the knowledge of an applicant for a post. This happened specifically in the cases of tutors who wanted to obtain jobs at the palace; they were invited with other applicants and asked to debate in front of

those who would hire them. The term mudhākarah seems to have been so synonymous with the term munāẓarah that in the ninth century when the Umayyad Prince of Spain, al-Mundhir ibn ‘Abd ar-Raḥmān (842-888), occasionally debated with his acquaintances regarding syntax, he called it mudhākarah. Even the Sufi community began to use the term for dhikr gatherings, but in a sense closer to the root meaning: mutual reminder.

44. Financially, mosques were maintained through charitable foundations, governed by the law of waqf. Throughout Islamic history, philanthropists donated large sums of money to waqf properties, including mosques. There is also historical evidence that by the eighth century, masjids as higher education institutions, began to pay their staff salaries and were able to grant their students free tuition, i.e., students did not have to pay fees. However, as Makdisi points out, the mosques were not used as lodgings or for subsistence.

45. It was Badr ibn Hasanwaih al-Kurdi (d. 1014), a governor appointed by …Buyid Sultan ‘Aḍud ad-Dawlah[21] (r. 978-983) in the tenth century, who triggered the advance of and long-lasting effects on educational institutions across the Caliphate. He established three thousand masjid-khan complexes in a period of thirty years throughout all the provinces that he administered for the Buyid dynasty. These complexes were further education mosques with study circles and adjunct inns (khan), where students who did not have lodgings and subsistence were able to reside throughout their study.

46. This was the second stage of the evolution of further education in Islamic history. Although there is evidence that scattered student inns existed before the governor Badr al-Kurdi, it is he who stands out as the cornerstone of the masjid-khan complex initiative. The khan that existed before the tenth century only served as a simple inn or a hotel for travellers, situated in the town, at the roadside or in the desert.

47. Higher education was provided at the khan adjunct to the mosques, whereas it is evident that other khans continued to be utilised as inns as was customary for travellers. Hence, the evolution of the mosque into the masjid-khan complex during the Buyid period (934-1055) of the ‘Abbasid Caliphate foreshadowed the development of the madrasah.

The Madrasah

[21] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/%27Adud_al-Dawla

48. It was during the early period of Seljuk rule in Baghdad that the madrasah was instituted by the minister Nizam al-Mulk[22] (d. 1092).

49. Nizam al-Mulk entered the service of the Seljuk Sultan Alp Arslan[23] (r. 1063-1072), the conqueror of Anatolia, in the year 1063 and by 1065 CE he had founded the Nizamiyyah madrasah of Baghdad. However, he not only established that madrasah but in addition numerous other madrasahs that were named after him throughout the 'Abbasid Caliphate in cities such as Nishapur, Balkh, Herat and Isfahan.

50. After Nizam al-Mulk, the pace of madrasah building accelerated throughout the Muslim world; rulers such as Nūr ad-Dīn of Damascus (r. 1146-1174) and the Ayyūbid dynasty of Egypt and Syria (1174-1250) founded numerous other madrasahs in the areas they ruled in the name of the 'Abbasid Caliph.

51. The Spanish Muslim traveller of Valencia, (d.1217), described the Nizamiyyah madrasahs in Baghdad as:

> ….There are approximately thirty madrasahs, all of which are on the East Side [of Baghdad], and there is not a single one of them but that a magnificent palace falls short of it in magnificence. The greatest and most famous among them is the Nizamiyyah, which is the one built by Nizam al-Mulk and reconstructed in the year 504 AH (1110 CE). The madrasahs have considerable endowments and landed property tied up inalienably, the proceeds of which go to the professors of law who teach there, who in turn grant scholarship from it to the students for their subsistence. Great honor and perpetual glory devolve upon this city because of these madrasahs and hospitals. May God be merciful towards the first of the founders and those who subsequently followed this pious practice.

52. The English term 'university' is derived from the Latin, 'universitas magistrorum et scholarium', translated as, 'community of teachers and scholars'. According to Hugh Goddard,[24] the Western university is an Islamic innovation in that the Islamic world was the first civilisation to introduce an institution of learning that centred on various faculties, as opposed opposed to the learning of antiquity that centred on specific individual teachers.

[22] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Nizam_al-Mulk
[23] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Alp_Arslan
[24] https://tinyurl.com/5a2z8f48

53. Historically, the first higher education institution in the Islamic world was al-Qayrawiyyīn in Fez founded in 899 CE by the Tunisian woman, Fāṭimah al-Fihrī.[25] The higher education institute of al-Azhar in Cairo was second in 969 CE, established by the Ismaili Shi'ite dynasty.

54. According to Makdisi, there is also a financial reason for the establishment of the madrasah. The legal status of the mosque as a waqf property is that it belongs to Allah because of His words, "The mosques belong to Allah" (Sūrat al-Jinn 72:18); it can neither be sold, rented or put to private use.

55. On the other hand, the waqf deed for a madrasah means that the founders of the madrasah can stipulate staff in the foundation deed and there is the possibility of carrying out a certain amount of long-term planning and thus benefitting academically from an exclusive higher education institution. The madrasah, nevertheless, did not bring educational activity in the mosques abruptly to an end; instead they existed side by side for centuries, with teaching going on in both congregational and local mosques.

56. The effect of the madrasah on the general population can be seen clearly in various historical sources. One of the main positive effects of the madrasah was upon financial benefits for the students. The waqf of a madrasah would provide salaries for staff and a large amount of scholarships for students. The students of the madrasah, in addition to the scholarship, were also provided with board and lodgings, a continuation of the masjid-khan tradition.

57. According to Stanton, this aspect of the madrasah is the historical origin of the residential colleges at Bologna, Paris, Oxford and Cambridge and also of the scholarships for impoverished scholars during the medieval period in Europe.

58. Another positive aspect of the madrasah was the incorporation of a library within the main structure of lecture halls and dormitories. It gave the students the opportunity to have first hand experience of numerous works and the different views of the scholars.

59. The impact of the Nizamiyyah madrasah was so great that Nizam al-Mulk founded further madrasahs also named Nizamiyyah in Balkh, Nishapur, Herat, Isfahan, Basra, Merw, Amul and Mosul. The impact and success of the madrasah movement did not stop here, but spread throughout the Muslim world. In Egypt, Sultan Ṣalāh ad-Dīn

[25] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fatima_al-Fihri

founded five madrasahs in Cairo; by the twelfth century madrasahs had spread throughout Iran, Iraq, Egypt, Palestine, Syria, and Central Asia.

60. The madrasahs founded by philanthropists became primarily colleges of law, which highlights Islam's focus on orthopraxy, 'right action', responding to the call of Allah through deeds. Sharī'ah has historically been the main focus of Muslim scholarship; the need for Islamic jurisprudence, which guides Muslim behaviour throughout life, has predominantly superseded the theoretical dedication to Muslim theology. Since the eleventh century, the teaching of jurisprudence in the mosques had mainly been identified with one of the four madhāhib. Hence, when the madrasahs came along, they followed in the same tradition; the madrasahs established by Nizam al-Mulk were all instituted with an accompanying endowment, which established them for the teaching of the Shāfi'ī madhhab. In contrast, the Sarakshī madrasah and the madrasah of Abū Ḥanīfah in Baghdad exclusively taught the Ḥanafī madhhab. The madrasah of Abū Sa'd al-Mukharrimī, later renamed after one of its most famous students, 'Abd al-Qādir al-Jīlānī, and the madrasah of Ibn al-Abradī were endowed to teach the Ḥanbalī madhhab.

61. The final stage of the madrasah's development in the 'Abbasid period occurred in the year 1234 CE when the 'Abbasid Caliph al-Mustanṣir (r.1226-1242) established the Mustanṣiriyyah madrasah. In contrast to many of the early madrasahs, which followed the tradition of the local mosques with regards to exclusively teaching only one madhhab, the Mustanṣiriyyah like the masjid al-jāmi' before it, began to teach all the madhāhib.

62. The waqf deed of the Mustanṣiriyyah madrasah makes it clear that it was more highly advanced than its predecessors. It includes all aspects of a modern university administration, such as a Chancellor (wāṣī), Vice Chancellor (nāẓir), Bursar (kātib), school officers (dīwān), Treasurer (mushrif), administrative staff, porters, librarians, bath manager, domestic servants and kitchen staff. Facilities such as a library, kitchen and public bath were clearly an advance over earlier madrasahs of the eleventh century.

63. In addition, at the request of the Caliph al-Mustanṣir, the new madrasah included a medical faculty where a doctor was appointed to lecture on medicine, pharmacy and natural sciences to a number of students who were offered stipends.380 One of the main features that distinguished the mosque from the madrasah during this period was that the madrasah was in some way directed by ministers and rulers of the state such as the Vizier Nizam al-Mulk and the Caliph al-Mustanṣir.

64. Ibn Baṭūṭah (d. 1369), the famous North African traveller, in the year 1327 CE described the Mustanṣiriyyah madrasah in Baghdad, which was then a century old:

> In the centre of this bazaar [the Tuesday Bazaar] is the wonderful Nizamiyyah College, the splendour of which is commemorated in a number of proverbial phrases, and at the end of it is the Mustanṣiriyyah College…All four schools are included in it, each school having a separate īwān, with its own mosque and lecture room. The teacher takes his place under a small wooden canopy, on a chair covered with rugs; he sits [on this] in a grave and quiet attitude, wearing robes of black and his [black turban], and with two assistants on his right and left, who repeat everything that he dictates. This same system is followed in every formal lecture of all four sections. Inside this college there is a bath-house for the students and a chamber for ablution.

65. Al-Ghazālī (1058-1111), a close friend of the Vizier Nizam al-Mulk, was offered a lectureship at the Nizamiyyah madrasah at the age of thirty-three. He noted that the period he lived in was experiencing an impediment to social change that was due to a misunderstanding involving the true purpose of education.382 He continually indicated in the Iḥyā' 'Ulūm ad-Dīn that there is no true learning without putting it into practice and using it for the betterment of society. He believed that society's aim is to apply the sharī'ah so that it can be possible to have a just and positive society. The aim of education is to nurture the human being so that he or she lives by the teachings of Islam, individually and socially, and at the same time is aware that human beings are ultimately created for the hereafter so that this is what they ultimately aspire to.383 Hence, to reach this goal al-Ghazālī integrated taṣawwuf and sharī'ah in his scholarship, so that the spirit of sharī'ah would be understood; he introduced the temporal modal logic to kalām to explain the faith and applied reasoning by analogy, deductive logic, and inductive logic within jurisprudence. Scholars who came after him such as Fakhr ad-Dīn ar-Rāzī (1149-1209) and Ibn Taymiyyah (1263-1328), also applied inductive logic to Islamic sharī'ah law.384 Both Gutas and Savage-Smith in their respective writings have demonstrated the successful impact of al-Ghazālī's scholarship on logic, philosophy and medicine in the Islamic world between the eleventh and fourteenth centuries and its legacy.385 This brings us to the potent question as to whether there was a decline in the intellectual life of the Muslims after al-Ghazālī's period? Many Western scholars have argued that from the eleventh and twelfth century onwards there was a decline in Islamic civilisation and many have spoken about the closing of the doors of ijtihād.

66. … instead that there was a continuing and creative intellectual tradition, not only in the heartlands of the 'Abbasids, but further west towards Egypt, Anatolia and Spain.

It is clear that the Mongol onslaught caused horrific destruction of Islamic civilisation in 1258 CE in the eastern part of the Caliphate, but it was only half a century later that the same Mongols became Muslim champions of art and science in the Islamic world. However, the devastated regions in Iraq and Central Asia never reached the same intellectual level as they had once achieved. Nevertheless, other regions of the Islamic world would have spectacular accomplishments in not only the intellectual world but also in the arenas of trade and politics. Although Europe commenced its rise from its 'Dark Ages' around the twelfth century, influenced strongly by Islamic civilisation, with the building of colleges in Bologna, Oxford, Cambridge and Paris, the majority of its population were still illiterate for centuries to come.

67. William H. McNeil and Marilyn Robinson Waldman in their book, The Islamic World, argue that Islamic civilisation continued to be amongst the major players in world history in the intellectual, political and military arenas until the eighteenth century, when the continuing impact of intellectual stagnation from within and colonisation from without brought 'Islamdom' to a standstill. During the late Middle Ages, Western civilisation slowly advanced from their 'Dark Ages' following four centuries of antagonistic clashes between Church and State reaching a position where, in most European countries, Church and State were separated. After the Peace Treaty of Westphalia in 1648, European civilisation moved towards the so-called 'Age of Enlightenment', where reason was advocated as the primary source of legitimacy and authority. In this intellectual amphitheatre, European nations such as Spain, Italy, Portugal, England and France moved towards aggressive economical, political and military expansion.